I hold my breath. It's as if I'm going under water. In seconds, I will resurface, again breaking the wall of consciousness. I take off on my left foot, on the balls of my feet, in a momentary image of a sprinter just out of their mark. I've played the same game this morning before play as I have done for every one of the 21 years as an England player, guessing where the run-up is before measuring it out, marking the guess down in paint. I haven't guessed it wrong for years. The left foot hits the marker I've laid out as I take off, spray paint underneath it. I mark it out as 15 paces, 1 jump at the start and 1 jump at the end as I pace it out – the exact measurement is 15.5 meters. Everything is in synchrony: the run, the past, the present and the future.

I begin to run in, and the feeling off the marker is like a springboard. I'm accelerating and, as I do, I'm close to a trance. I know I'm in good flow because it feels like I'm gliding. There is no conscious effort anywhere. I have had days where I've approached the crease and felt out of breath, where every step is a chore, but today it's not taking anything out of me whatsoever. Someone has told me this week that if you collate every time I've done this back to back, I would be running in uninterrupted for 18 and a half days non-stop for England. Today, in this moment, I feel like I could do it all again. I'd be running in until no one is in the ground any more, just watching the ball do what it does.

I become weightless, floating, my feet and knees unburdened by any impact with the ground. Everything outside becomes meaningless. There is no one else inside the moment. Only me and the ball. The thoughts; all the processing, all the information, the chatter in the background, my teammates, my opponents, the objectives, the history, the future, the success, the failures, the score, it all evaporates. They are an echo of something unnecessary. I am nothing but a combination of pure forward motion and stillness. Josh Da Silva is in my periphery; a blurry, flinching distance which is getting closer and closer. I have a sense of him, but that is all. I'm focusing on tempo only. I'm trying to swing the ball, so I'm not running in as fast as I once would have – it's all control, rhythm and tempo.

As I begin to reach the wicket, I become aware that I've been concentrating on the approaching crease. It comes into focus quickly and as it does, almost like a set of auto-pilot instructions with a pre-determined destination dialled in, I begin the delivery stride. Umpires will say to me,